MAY-2025 NEWSLETTER

VENTURES VOYAGE

ENTREPRENEURSHIP IN TRAVEL

Innovative Business Models Enhancing Travel Experiences

NEWSLETTER BY BUDDING ENTREPRENEURS FORUM

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INTRODUCTION

Entrepreneurship in Travel – Innovative Business Models Enhancing Travel Experiences.

As the holiday season sets in and wanderlust takes over, the world of travel is no longer just about reaching a destination—it's about curating unique, memorable experiences. With changing traveler preferences and the rise of digital platforms, the travel industry has become a fertile ground for entrepreneurial innovation. From adventure-based startups like Trek Panda, which connects strangers on thrilling expeditions, to global disruptors like Airbnb, redefining accommodation norms—entrepreneurs are reshaping the way we explore the world.

In this special edition, we dive deep into the evolving landscape of travel entrepreneurship. Our articles spotlight top tourism companies, both Indian and foreign, that have successfully navigated the Indian market, as well as failed ventures, offering critical insights into what makes or breaks a travel startup. We also explore the influential role of travel influencers, both male and female, who are turning passion into profession and becoming key players in destination marketing.

Each piece aims to uncover the business models, growth strategies, and lessons learned, giving readers a 360-degree view of the travel entrepreneurship ecosystem. Whether you're an aspiring travelpreneur or a curious traveler, this edition promises an exciting journey through stories of success, innovation, and resilience.

Written By:
Sushmita Poojari
MBA - Finance

Entrepreneurship in Travel : Indian Innovative Business Models Enhancing Travel Experiences

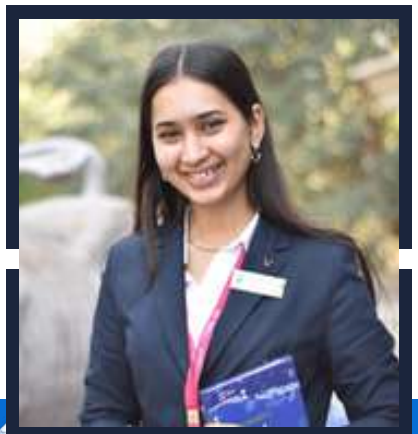
The Indian travel industry is growing fast and entrepreneurs are using original ideas to design travel more fascinating and comfortable. One top name in this space is thomas cook india a well-established company that has reinvented itself with modern and tech-savvy travel solutions.

Primarily known for basic travel bookings and tours, thomas cook india has transformed over the years today it offers tailor made holiday packages travel loans. Yes, you can now pay for your trip in installments, forex cards for international travel and even travel insurance their easy-to-use website and mobile app make planning a vacation, smooth and quick.

They have added special experience-based trips like adventure holidays, heritage tours and wellness retreats. All this is managed through their user-friendly website and mobile app which helps travelers plan and book everything in one place. They also provide curated experiences like heritage walks, adventure sports, lavishness getaways and even special honeymoon or senior citizen tours. This shows how a traditional company can support innovation to stay relevant and meet the changing needs of modern travelers.

Thomas Cook India proves that innovation is not just for startups, even large companies can act like entrepreneurs by understanding what customers want and offering value packed experiences.

Thomas Cook



Written By:
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Building Bridges: G Adventures' Journey of Partnership and Growth

G Adventures is a Canadian-based tourism company founded in the 1990s, one of the powerful leaders in adventure travel, that has demonstrated how strategic collaboration can influence and fuel substantial growth by forging partnerships with local communities, global alliances, and niche travel operators. G Adventures has created unique adventure and travel experiences while supporting sustainable tourism.

A prime example of the collaboration of the company with the local guides and small businesses in remote destinations, while fostering the authentic cultural growth, exchange, and economic benefits for the locals. Collaborating with local airlines and established tour operators has broadened G Adventures' global presence, boosted booking and fostered customer trust. This diverse partnership strategy has led to a notable increase in bookings, resulting in continuous revenue annual growth, even in competitive markets. By focusing on the partnership, the company has demonstrated the advantages of collaboration over rivalry, showcasing how significantly it can drive sustainable growth in the tourism industry.

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Written By:
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The Fall of Travel Tours Group: A Cautionary Tale in Indian Tourism

Travel Tours Group, one of South India's indigenous names in the tourism space, is a fascinating case study on how even dominant brands come undone. Founded in the 1970s, it streaked to world popularity by offering tailored holiday packages, visa processing, and corporate travel. Decades later, it remained the preferred choice of locals and global travelers alike.

But as the travel situation began to change radically in the 2000s, Travel Tours found it difficult to keep up. The arrival of online travel websites (OTAs) like MakeMyTrip, Yatra, and Cleartrip disrupted the traditional business model. These new, online-only sites offered convenience, competitive rates, and 24/7 service, while Travel Tours clung to outdated offline habits.

The company was also not expanding at the national level and acquiring newer, more tech-savvy customers. Its failure to invest in internet marketing, as well as operational inefficiencies and growing competition, further eroded its market presence. In addition, internal complacency, coupled with a lack of strategic leadership, further worsened the situation.

Later, Travel Tours Group was acquired by FCM Travel Solutions, a global Indian subsidiary of Flight Centre Travel Group. Though the brand name still exists as part of FCM's retail business, it is no longer a standalone Indian entity.

The demise of Travel Tours is a poignant reminder that balancing the high wire of reputation and tradition with being open to innovation and flexibility is crucial, especially in the fast-changing tourism environment of the present day.

Written By:
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The End of an Era: What went wrong with Thomas Cook

Many foreign tourism companies have entered new countries with high hopes, but not all succeed. A well-known example is Thomas Cook, a British travel company that shut down in 2019 after nearly 180 years in business. Th e main reason for their failure was their inability to adapt. As more travelers started booking holidays online, Thomas Cook continued relying on physical stores and fixed travel packages. This old model became outdated quickly , especially as modern travelers preferred flexibility and cheaper options they could book themselves. The company also struggled with heavy debt and rising costs from running too many offices.

While the world was moving toward digital -platforms and personalized experiences, Thomas Cook was stuck in the past.Their slow response to changing customer habits, technology, and global travel trends eventually caught up with them.

The story of Thomas Cook teaches us a simple but important lesson: no matter how big or historic a company is, it must keep up with the times. Understanding what customers want,staying financially lean, and embracing change are key to survival in today's fast-moving world. When businesses ignore these signs, even decades of experience can't save them.

Thomas Cook

Written By:
Varad Mulgund
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MALE INFLUENCER IN TOURISM INDUSTRY

Meet Naman Bardiya !

Naman Bardiya is someone who truly stands out when it comes to energy, curiosity, and creativity. He has a natural passion for entrepreneurship and is always full of ideas that aim to solve real problems. What makes Naman special is not just his thinking, but also his willingness to take action. He believes in learning by doing, and you'll often find him involved in projects, events, or brainstorming sessions with a notebook full of ideas.

Aside from his passion for business, Naman is an excellent team player. He listens, communicates his ideas clearly, and ensures everyone is included. Whether one is coordinating something new or assisting with chores, he has a favorable attitude that inspires the entire group.

What also makes him commendable is that he is so down-to-earth. Despite all that ambition and motivation, he's still humble and friendly. You can always talk to him nicely about anything from startups to college life or something light.

In a world where most people are still looking for direction, Naman is someone who is already on a journey with direction and passion—and guiding others along the way.

Written By:
Samiksha Pazare
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Brinda Sharma: Telling Stories Involving Travel Through Her Very Own Perspective

Having established herself as a leading Indian travel influencer, Brinda Sharma has transformed the tourism industry with her exciting travel vlogs and captivating narration. Brinda, with over 1.2 million followers on Instagram, is changing the perception of travel content in India as she has a strong following on YouTube as well. Her vlogs are cinematic in nature, portraying dazzling sights alongside genuine insights about different locations, and they travel with her across India and other countries.

The combination of culture, adventure, and local activities captured through her lens makes travel seem not only inspiring but also achievable to young solo travelers. She practices sustainable tourism by drawing attention to places that are less traveled to and persuading people to travel responsibly. Her partnerships with big brands such as OYO Rooms, Titan, and Red Bull have furthered her impact in customizing contemporary travel.

Following Brinda's lead, travel by younger generations has turned into a spontaneous activity full of creativity, as she provides them with practical traveling advice. She is actively shifting the direction of modern tourism by portraying it in a different light as her influence goes beyond mere visuals. Sharma promotes inclusivity and sustainability in travel, which is why the change brought forth by her will surely be lasting. With her videos and photography, Brinda Sharma encourages meaningful exploration and travel.

Written By:
Vedashree Ghokar
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How Airbnb and Its Users Make Money

Airbnb has transformed the travel industry by enabling people to monetize spaces and services they already have. But how exactly does the platform and its users make money?

Airbnb's Revenue Model

Service Fees are Airbnb's primary income source. Every time a booking is made, Airbnb charges both the guest and the host a percentage. Guests usually pay up to 14%, while hosts pay around 3% per booking. This small cut from millions of bookings adds up to billions in revenue.

Airbnb Experiences is another growing stream. Locals can host tours, workshops, or classes, and Airbnb takes a 20% commission per experience booked.

How Individuals Earn on Airbnb

1.Hosting a Property-

Homeowners or renters list extra rooms or vacant homes. For many, this income helps cover rent or mortgages, especially in tourist-friendly cities.

2. Co-Hosting-

Don't have a property? Co-hosts manage other people's listings — handling bookings, guest messages, and maintenance — for a share of the earnings (often 10–20%).

3. Offering Experiences-

Locals can share hobbies like cooking, music, or hiking. These personalized activities can earn hosts ₹2,000–₹10,000 per session.

Written By:
Yash Mutha
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Conclusion

The travel industry has developed into a vibrant hub of creativity, customization, and entrepreneurship that encompasses more than just lodging and transportation. By providing a range of services like travel loans, curated experiences, and digital convenience, companies like Thomas Cook India have effectively reinvented themselves and demonstrated that established brands can stay relevant through ongoing innovation.

In the meantime, G Adventures serves as an example of how cooperation with regional and international partners can promote cultural impact and sustainable growth. Platforms such as Airbnb enable people to make money off of their skills and spaces, generating a global network of genuine travel experiences and flexible income options.

Thomas Cook

airbnb

G Adventures

At the local level, business owners such as Naman Bardiya are prime examples of how enthusiasm, ingenuity, and collaboration can spark successful endeavors. Travel experiences are changing as a result of this entrepreneurial wave, becoming more immersive, interesting, and community-focused.

As highlighted in this edition, the future of travel rests with those who have the courage to think outside the box, work together to create, and adapt to the evolving needs of contemporary explorers, as this special edition emphasizes. Innovation and adaptability are the real keys to success in the rapidly changing travel industry, whether you're a startup, a multinational corporation or an individual.

Written By:
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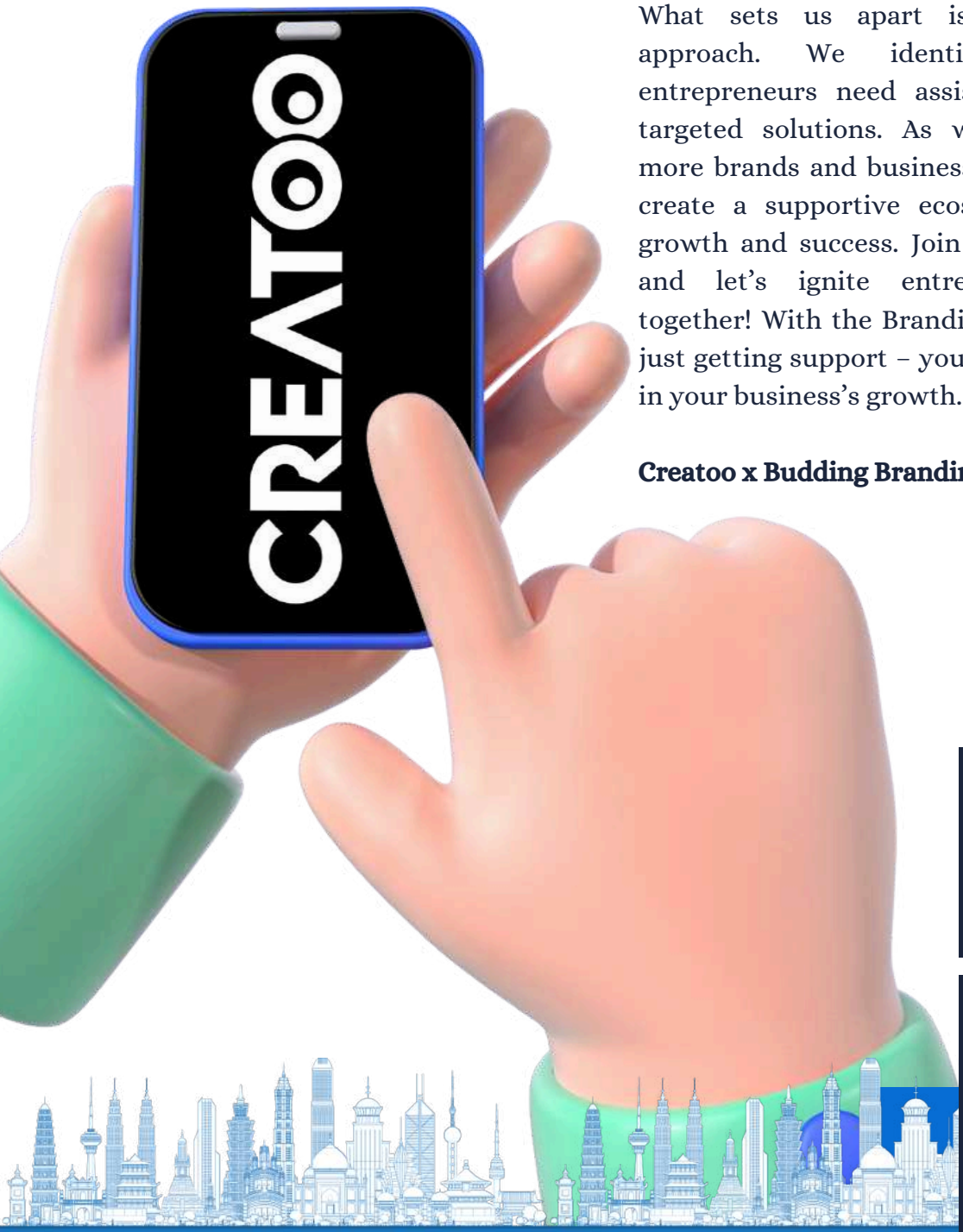
Igniting Entrepreneurial Dreams: The Branding Team's Story

Imagine having a platform that understands your entrepreneurial struggles and offers tailored solutions to boost your business. Welcome to the Branding Team, launched by Budding Entrepreneurs Forum in February 2025. We're on a mission to empower small-scale entrepreneurs like you.

Our team provides strategic growth solutions, creates brand awareness, and offers social media support, website building, and more. We're currently working with Creatoo, helping them amplify their brand presence. Our goal is to bridge the gap between entrepreneurial potential and practical growth strategies.



What sets us apart is our personalized approach. We identify areas where entrepreneurs need assistance and provide targeted solutions. As we collaborate with more brands and businesses, we're excited to create a supportive ecosystem that fosters growth and success. Join us on this journey, and let's ignite entrepreneurial dreams together! With the Branding Team, you're not just getting support – you're gaining a partner in your business's growth.

Creatoo x Budding Branding Team

Written By:
Sanjana Kashyap
FY MBA HR

PODCAST

"Your Idea, Your Move: Empowering Startup Dreams with No-Code"

Host: Urja Wadgaye

In today's digital world, launching a startup is easier than ever—especially with no-code platforms like Workat, which empower anyone to build apps without writing code. But tools alone don't create success. The real fuel is an entrepreneurial mindset: curiosity, resilience, and bold risk-taking.

Take Sagnik Ghosh, an alumni of MIT-WPU and a young innovator who turned early passion for technology into a startup that helps others build faster. He resisted traditional career paths, followed his interests, and used setbacks as lessons. Sagnik's story shows that mindset shapes success more than resources do.

Platforms like Workat level the playing field, letting startups and enterprises quickly create tools to manage operations, automate tasks, and test ideas without costly developers. With AI integration, even non-technical founders can innovate smarter.
However, startup life isn't without challenges—earning trust, managing teams, and navigating regulations all take grit. But with support, real-world feedback, and the courage to stand out, young entrepreneurs can thrive.

The message is clear: build what people want, stay persistent, and act boldly. With no-code tools and the right mindset, your idea could be the next big thing. Start now, and let your passion power the future.

Hack MIT-WPU 2025: A Sprint of Innovation.

MIT World Peace University successfully hosted Hack MIT-WPU 2025, a high-energy intra-university hackathon that brought together creative minds from across its various schools. Held on March 8–9, 2025, this hybrid event challenged students to think beyond boundaries under the theme: **"Innovating for a Better Tomorrow."**

The hackathon saw enthusiastic participation from interdisciplinary teams of 2 to 4 members, who worked intensively to address real-world challenges across five core domains: Health and wellness, Education, Sustainability, Finance and commerce, and Open Innovation. Students showcased their ability to blend creativity with technology in developing innovative, impactful solutions within a tight timeframe.

In the weeks leading up to the event, participants engaged in mentoring sessions and preparatory workshops conducted by faculty and industry professionals. These sessions offered guidance on ideation, prototyping, and effective pitching, equipping teams with the skills to perform under pressure. Hack MIT-WPU 2025 was judged in multiple rounds by a diverse panel of experts. Entries were evaluated based on innovation, feasibility, social relevance, and execution. The competition fostered a strong spirit of collaboration and problem-solving, with many teams proposing solutions that could be scaled or incubated further.

The event also drew support from corporate sponsors, who came on board as Title Sponsors, Gold and Silver Partners, and Knowledge Collaborators. Sponsors benefited from brand visibility, direct interaction with emerging talent, and opportunities to contribute to the innovation ecosystem nurtured at MIT-WPU. The hackathon was spearheaded by a dedicated team of the Budding Entrepreneurs Forum. Students and faculty jointly managed event execution, marketing, outreach, and logistics. Their seamless coordination ensured a smooth experience for all involved, both online and on campus.

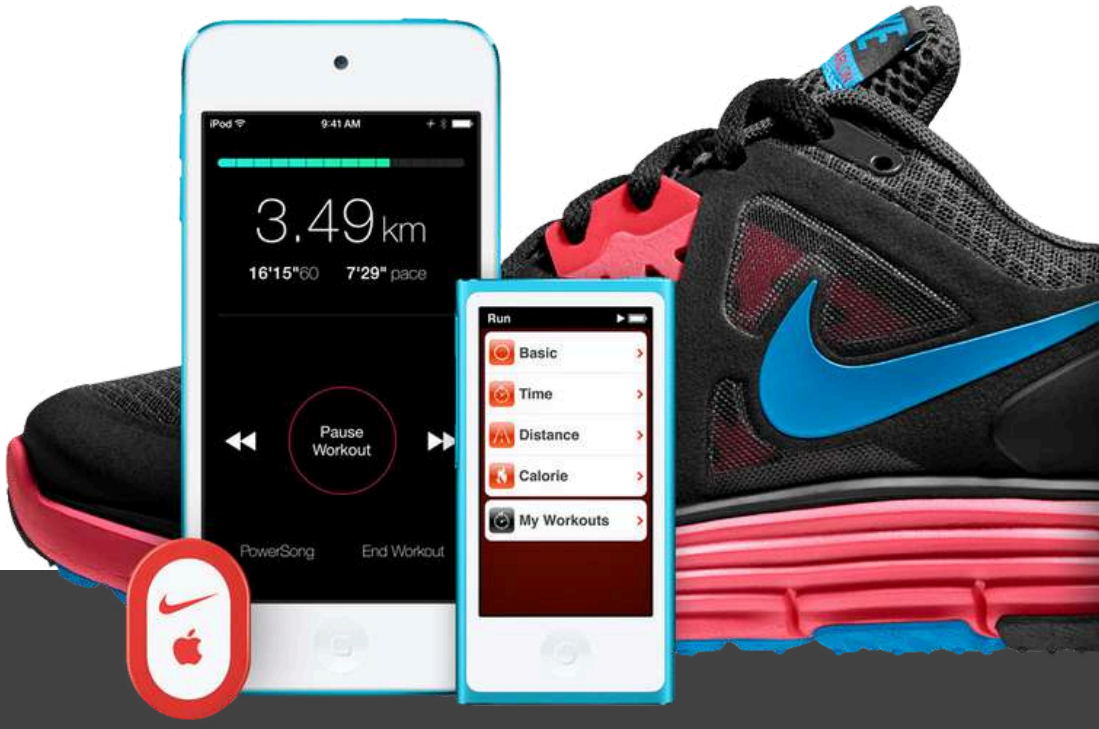
Hack MIT-WPU 2025 stood out as more than just a coding event—it became a platform for students to take initiative, think entrepreneurially, and collaborate across disciplines. The energy, ideas, and execution demonstrated throughout the event reflected the university's commitment to fostering future-ready, socially conscious innovators.
As the event concluded, it left behind not only winning solutions but also lasting inspiration for the students and mentors who were part of this remarkable journey.

HackMITWPU'25
IDEATHON
Division 2
ONE HACKATHON, SIXTEEN TRACKS
MILLION PROBLEMS, BILLION MIND
ले छलांग

Running with Innovation: The Nike+iPod Success Story

In 2006, Apple and Nike came together to create something new that blended fitness with technology. Their goal was to make workouts smarter, more fun, and easier to track. This led to the launch of the Nike+iPod Sport Kit, a product that helped people monitor their runs using a small sensor inside their Nike+ shoes. The sensor connected to an iPod nano and gave users updates while they ran—like how far they had gone, how fast they were moving, and how many calories they had burned.

What made this special was not just the technology, but how it motivated people to move more. After running, users could upload their data to the Nike+ website, check their progress, set personal goals, and even challenge friends. This created one of the first online fitness communities, years before fitness apps became common.

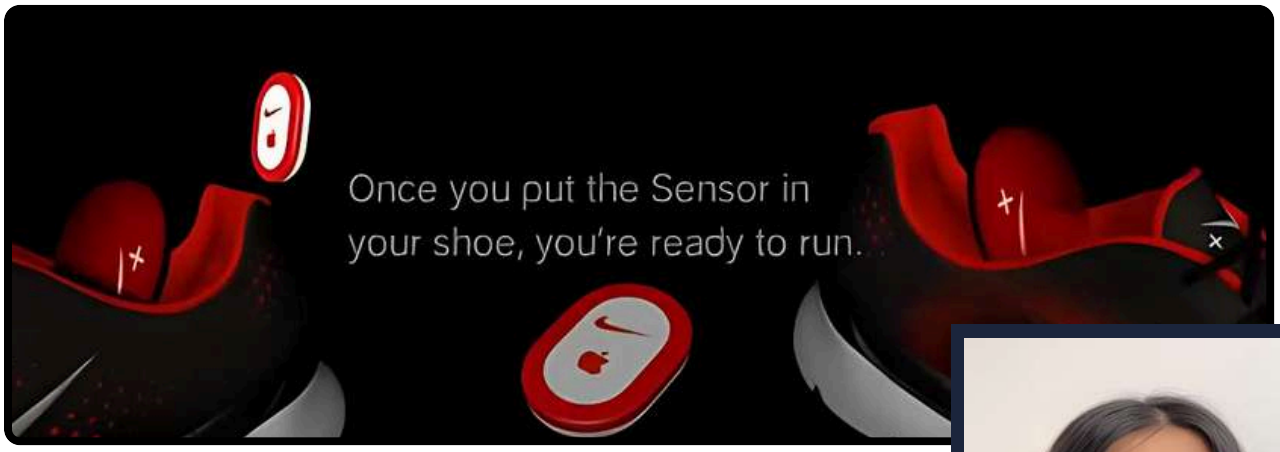


How It Helped Both Companies

This partnership gave both Apple and Nike big benefits. For Apple, it was a smart way to show that the iPod could do more than just play music. It became a part of people's active lifestyle. As a result, iPod sales went up, especially among fitness lovers. This also helped Apple understand how people use wearable devices, which later influenced the creation of the Apple Watch—a product that became a huge success.
Nike also gained a lot. The Nike+ system made their shoes more appealing and brought in customers who were excited about using technology to improve their workouts. It helped Nike build stronger relationships with its customers and made the brand look more modern and innovative. The data collected through the Nike+ platform also gave the company valuable insights into customer behavior.

Long-Term Impact

Even though the original Nike+iPod product was eventually discontinued, the partnership didn't end there. Apple and Nike continued to work together, and today, the Apple Watch Nike edition is a popular product that combines Apple's design and Nike's fitness features.
This collaboration is now seen as one of the best examples of how two different companies can work together to create something completely new. It not only brought financial success but also shaped the future of wearable fitness technology. It showed the world that when design, innovation, and purpose come together, the results can truly change how people live and move.



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Tanaya Zad
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What's Happening in Entrepreneurship World ?

1. Startup Mahakumbh 2025 – India's Largest Startup Festival
Date: April 3–5, 2025 | Venue: New Delhi

The Government of India organised this mega event which has brought more than 10,000 startups, 500+ investors and policymakers under one roof. Deep tech innovation, sustainable venture and women entrepreneurship were the key themes. An announcement of ₹1,000 crore seed fund was done by the Union Commerce Minister for startups from tier 2 and tier 3 cities. The event also included a Pitch Fest where 50 early stage entrepreneurs had competed for financing.

2. Bharat Shiksha Expo 2025: Empowering India's Next-Gen Entrepreneurs
Date: April 16–18, 2025 | Venue: India Expo Mart, Greater Noida

The Bharat Shiksha Expo 2025 is a national education exhibition that promotes innovation, entrepreneurship and technology in education. It aspires to empower India's future generation entrepreneurs by displaying innovative educational technology and encouraging networking and collaboration between academics and the workplace. The exhibition has featured interactive learning sessions and information hubs as well as a Creathon Innovation Challenge. Overall, the event has aimed to provide a complete forum for researching the most recent trends and developments in education as well as encouraging innovation and entrepreneurship.

What's Happening in Entrepreneurship World ?

3. StartCo
Date: April 3–4, 2025 | Venue: Medellín, Colombia

StartCo is a large scale entrepreneurship and innovation event which is notable for being Latin America's first live startup auction. The entrepreneurs had presented their ideas and investors made real time offers. StartCo has welcomed over 13,000 guests from 20 countries strengthening their status as the region's leading centre for technology and entrepreneurship. With a focus on companies with minimum revenues of $25,000 per year, the event has helped founders to raise investment and establish relationships with other players in the ecosystem. This is an experience in which more than 11,000 entrepreneurs have pitched their ideas live where they have fetched multimillion dollar investments in real time.

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